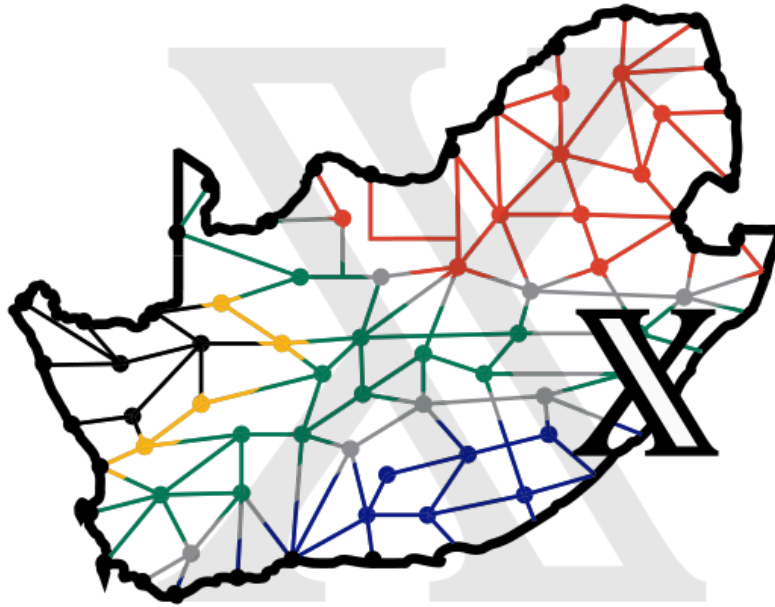




Deep Learning Indaba **X**
South Africa 2026

Post-event Report

Kwa-Zulu Natal, South Africa | 6 – 9 July 2026

Version 1

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1 EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

IndabaX South Africa 2026 generated strong demand and assembled a highly representative, student-led community around a five-day programme in KwaZulu-Natal. The supplied records show 391 applications, 189 final acceptances, a near-equal waitlist of 191 people, 130 grant awards, and 39 accepted poster proposals. These figures indicate that the principal constraint was capacity and access to funding rather than interest.

391	189	130	13
Application records	Accepted participants	Grant awards	Number of sponsors & partners
29	2	R788,724.36	R16,227.93
Number of posters	Number of Hackathons	Recorded expenses	Recorded deficit

1.1 Overall assessment

The graph below illustrates the overall final selection outcomes for all applications received.

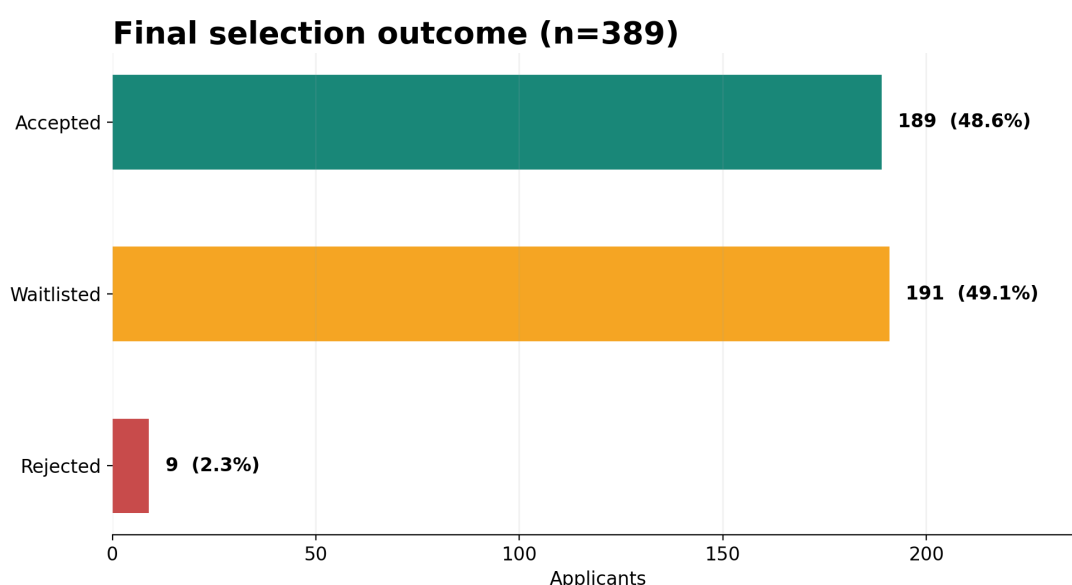


Figure 1. Final selection outcome.

2 EVENT CONTEXT AND STRATEGIC ALIGNMENT

The Deep Learning IndabaX South Africa is positioned as the annual meeting of the South African machine learning and artificial intelligence community and as a national chapter of the pan-African Deep Learning Indaba movement. The event took place at the University of KwaZulu-Natal (Westville Campus) in KwaZulu-Natal from 6-10 July 2026, with close to 270 in-person delegates. This is a drop from previous years, where the number of delegates

exceeded 400. Various factors contributed to the decline, including the recent nationwide marches against illegal immigration, with the epicentre being Kwa-Zulu Natal.

2.1 Mission alignment

Objective	Evidence in 2026
Spread scientific knowledge	The applicant pool was predominantly early-career, and more than half selected Beginner or Basic machine-learning levels.
Showcase industry applications	The programme design included AI Fest, exhibitions, partner stands and industry sessions.
Provide a practical introduction	338 applicants wanted to join the hackathon; demand was strongest for real-life implementation.
Build responsible AI practice	The advertised programme included AI ethics, safety, governance and responsible-AI themes.

2.2 The five-day programme

Day	Advertised components
Mon 6 July	Registration, campus exploration, keynote, AI Fest, poster session and group photo
Tue 7 July	Keynotes, tutorials, lectures, hackathon practical and movie night
Wed 8 July	Keynotes, tutorials, lectures, flash talks, meetups, mentorship and hackathon
Thu 9 July	Keynotes, tutorials, lectures, workshops, prize-giving, closing ceremony and closing event
Fri 10 July	Check-out, exploration of KwaZulu-Natal and return travel

2.3 Directional comparison with the 2025 benchmark

Indicator	2025 prospectus	2026 supplied record	Interpretation
Women	44% of 2025 attendees	49.7% of the 2026 accepted cohort	Improved representation, but the population bases differ.
Posters	60 posters	103 accepted proposals	The 2026 acceptance pipeline is 71.7% larger; final presentation count is unverified.
Travel support	45 travel grants	85 transport-support recipients	Substantially expanded access support; definitions differ.
Accommodation	65 accommodation grants	83 people on the accommodation manifest	27.7% above the 2025 count; 115 awards were initially recorded.
Attendance	400+ attendees	250 expected roster entries; actual attendance unverified	The supplied records do not substantiate the 400+ target.

3 APPLICATION DEMAND AND SELECTION

The 391-application pool demonstrates broad interest in IndabaX South Africa. The final selection file contains 389 records: 189 accepted, 191 waitlisted, and 9 rejected. The waitlist is slightly larger than the accepted cohort, indicating unmet demand and a need to align venue, budget, and selection capacity earlier in the next cycle.

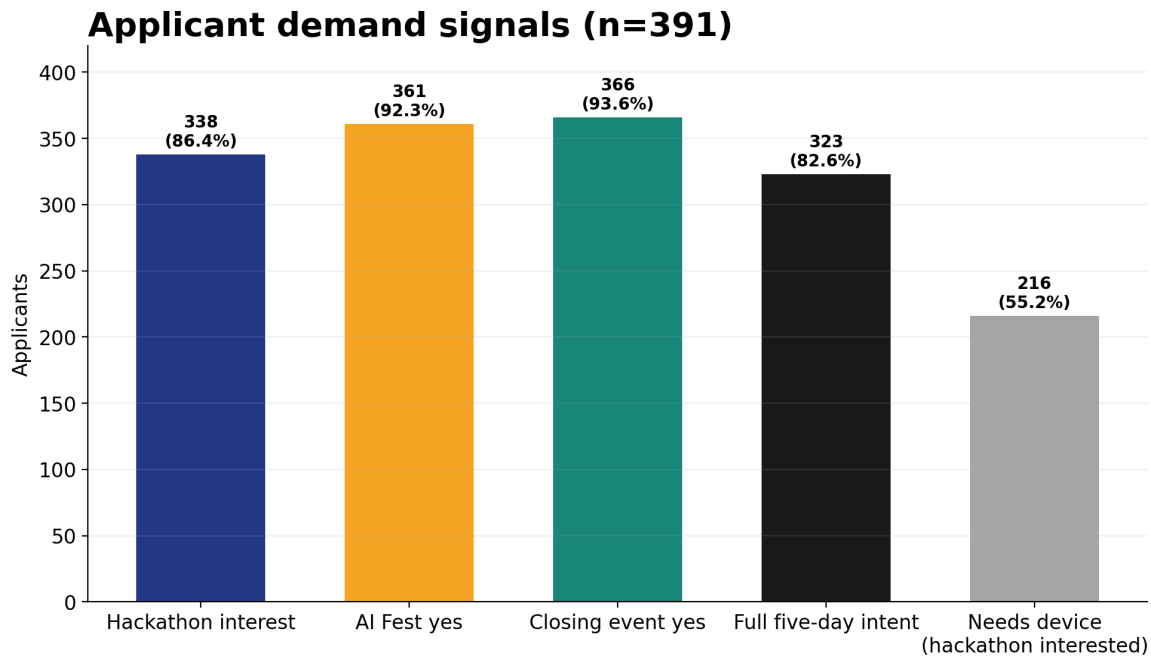


Figure 2: Applicant demand signals. Percentages use all 391 application records as the denominator

3.1 Key demand indicators

Indicator	Count	Share	Interpretation
Hackathon participation	338	86.4%	A core programme driver.
Device required for hackathon	216	55.2%	Equivalent to 63.9% of hackathon-interested applicants.
Full five-day attendance intent	323	82.6%	High demand for the complete programme.
AI Fest attendance - Yes	361	92.3%	Strong opening-event demand.
Closing event attendance - Yes	366	93.6%	Strong closing-event demand.
Prior ML conference experience	101	25.8%	Approximately three-quarters were new to such events.

3.2 Learning priorities

Topic	Applicants	Share of applicants
Real-life applications and implementation	202	51.7%
Large Language Models	53	13.6%
Computer Vision	46	11.8%
Reinforcement Learning	30	7.7%
Probabilistic models	22	5.6%
Basics of neural networks	19	4.9%
Model Deployment on NPUs	11	2.8%

Topic	Applicants	Share of applicants
Model Distillation	5	1.3%

Because topic selection allowed multiple responses, the percentages do not sum to 100%. The strongest signal is a desire for real-life implementation, followed by large language models and computer vision. This supports a programme mix weighted toward practical laboratories, case studies and deployable systems.

3.3 Funding need at application stage

Funding position	Applicants	Share
Transport and accommodation	253	64.7%
Accommodation only	52	13.3%
Transport only	22	5.6%
Support requested; alternative possible	3	0.8%
Self-funded	61	15.6%

In total, 330 applicants (84.4%) requested some form of support. This confirms that the access-support budget is central to the event model rather than an ancillary benefit.

4 PARTICIPANT PROFILE AND INCLUSION

The accepted cohort is strongly aligned with IndabaX South Africa's community-development mission. It achieved exact female-male parity among binary-gender records, included one non-binary participant, and was overwhelmingly composed of students and early-career researchers.

4.1 Gender and representation

Population	Gender	Count	Share
Applications	Female	194	49.6%
Applications	Male	196	50.1%
Applications	Non-binary	1	0.3%
Accepted	Female	94	49.7%
Accepted	Male	94	49.7%
Accepted	Non-binary	1	0.5%
Funded	Female	68	52.3%
Funded	Male	62	47.7%

Women represented 52.3% of the funded cohort, slightly above their share of the accepted cohort. The poster cohort was less balanced: 41 of 103 accepted poster proposals (39.8%) were submitted by women, creating a 9.9 percentage-point gap relative to the accepted cohort.

4.2 Ethnicity and transformation indicators

Ethnicity	Accepted	Accepted share	Funded	Funded share
Black	160	84.7%	118	90.8%
Indian	14	7.4%	5	3.8%
White	11	5.8%	3	2.3%
Coloured	3	1.6%	3	2.3%
North African	1	0.5%	1	0.8%

Interpretation caution These figures describe representation in the supplied categories. They are not a formal B-BBEE calculation, compliance assessment, or equity audit.

4.3 Career stage

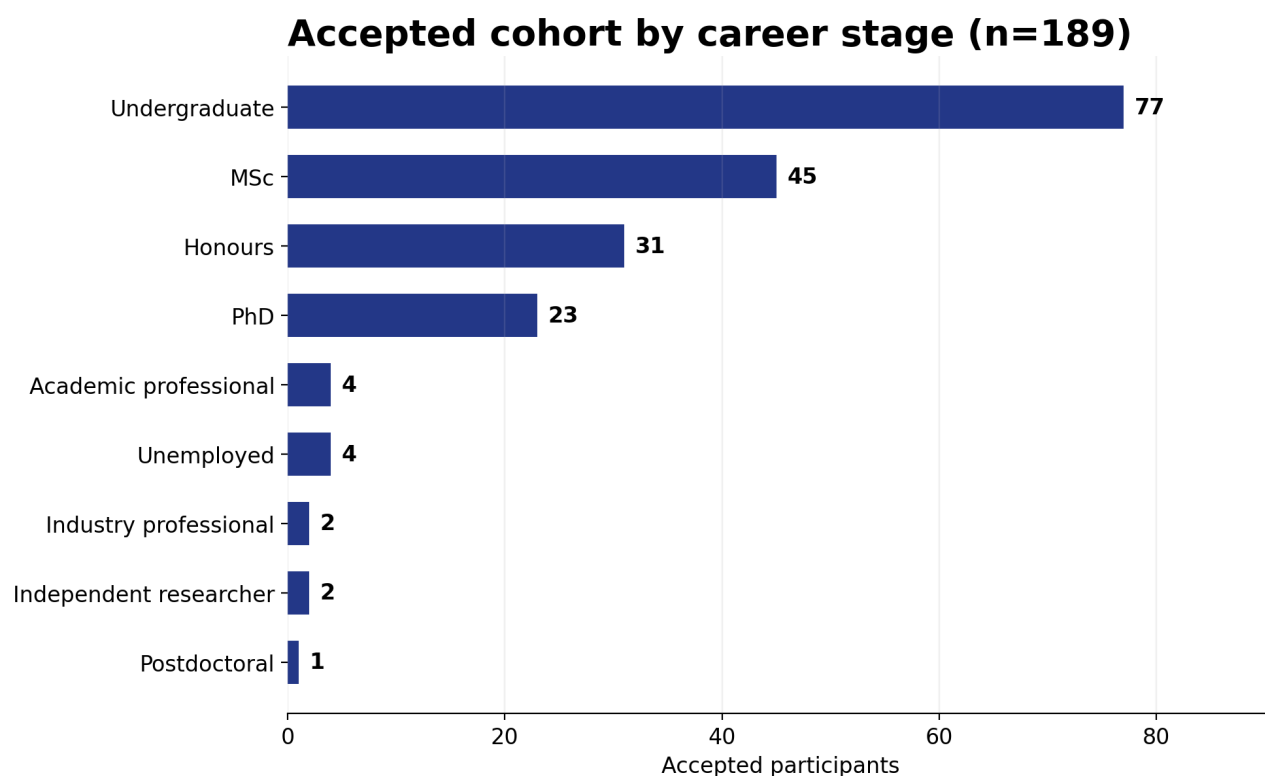


Figure 4: Accepted cohort by career stage

177 of 189 accepted participants (93.7%) were students or postdoctoral researchers. Undergraduates formed the largest group, followed by MSc, Honours and PhD students. This profile supports a programme that combines foundational instruction, research exposure, mentorship and career pathways.

4.4 Geographic reach

The application residence field records 363 South African residents (92.8%) and 28 applicants resident in 15 other countries. The nationality field is more pan-African: 93 applications recorded a non-South-African nationality. In the accepted cohort, 179 of 189 country entries were South African, with 10 participants representing seven other countries.

The event, therefore, achieved continental reach at the top of the funnel, but the final accepted cohort was primarily domestic. Future international participation should be planned with explicit targets, visa timelines, funding rules, and separate self-funded/invited pathways.

5 ACCESS SUPPORT AND LOGISTICS

Access support was one of the defining features of the 2026 event. The final selection file records 130 funded participants, equivalent to 68.8% of the accepted cohort. The award mix included accommodation, scheduled bus transport, cash travel stipends and combinations of these benefits.

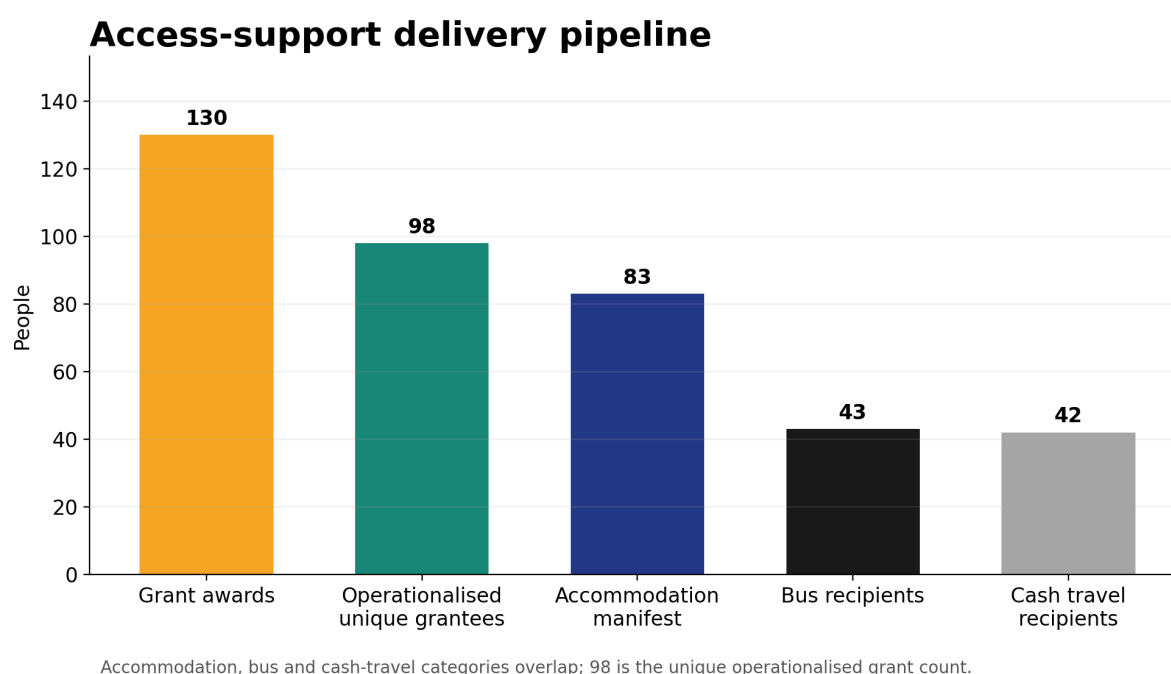


Figure 5: Grant award and operationalisation pipeline. Categories overlap except for the unique totals.

5.1 Award and manifest reconciliation

Measure	People
Unique funded awards	130
Unique operationalised grantees	98
Accommodation awards	115
Accommodation manifest	83
Bus recipients	43
Cash travel recipients	42
Accommodation-only awards not in manifest	32

The 32-record operationalisation gap consists entirely of accommodation-only awards that were not present in the final accommodation manifest. This could represent declined awards, missed registration deadlines, duplicate/changed arrangements or a data integration gap. A final status code is needed for each record.

5.2 Transport support

Support element	Recipients	Recorded amount
Cash travel stipends	42	R75,570.00
Bus access stipends	43	R4,950.00
Bus contract in budget	-	R74,400.00
Student travel grants in budget	-	R74,600.00
Organiser travel in budget	-	R35,800.00
Bus snacks in budget	-	R3,600.00

The bus manifest includes 43 people, of whom 36 had direct Johannesburg/Pretoria depot access and seven required early travel from other locations. The bus-access stipends total R4,950 and are separate from the R74,400 bus contract.

6 PROGRAMME, RESEARCH AND INNOVATION

The prospectus describes a high-intensity programme spanning keynotes, lectures, tutorials, workshops, meetups, mentorship, AI Fest, posters, exhibitions, hackathons, debates and awards. Applicant demand strongly supports this design: 338 people wanted to join the hackathon, 361 planned to attend AI Fest and 323 intended to attend all five days.

6.1 Hackathon capacity

The advertised 2026 hackathon plan included a guided Isazi stream, beginner and advanced InstaDeep streams and an astronomy research hackathon. The strongest operational constraint was computing access: 216 hackathon-interested applicants (63.9% of that group) said they would need a borrowed laptop or supplied PC.

- Publish device-allocation criteria and confirm equipment before participants travel.
- Use pre-event environment checks and cloud credits to reduce setup time.
- Cap streams by mentor and device capacity, not only venue capacity.
- Record registrations, active participants, submissions, completions, winners and post-event repository links.

6.2 AI Fest and industry engagement

The exhibitor form contains seven organisation submissions spanning industry, academia, non-profit and research institutions. The partner form contains five organisation submissions. These records show a practical focus on responsible AI, health, conservation, education, research computing and applied AI solutions. Final reporting should add booth attendance, demonstrations delivered, contacts generated and partner satisfaction.

7 8. REGISTRATION AND ATTENDANCE

The expected registration roster contains 250 entries across attendees, organisers, academia, speakers, partners, industry, exhibitors, a guest and a photographer. Forty-six entries are explicitly marked absent; 204 are not marked absent. No signature fields are populated, so the records cannot confirm actual attendance.

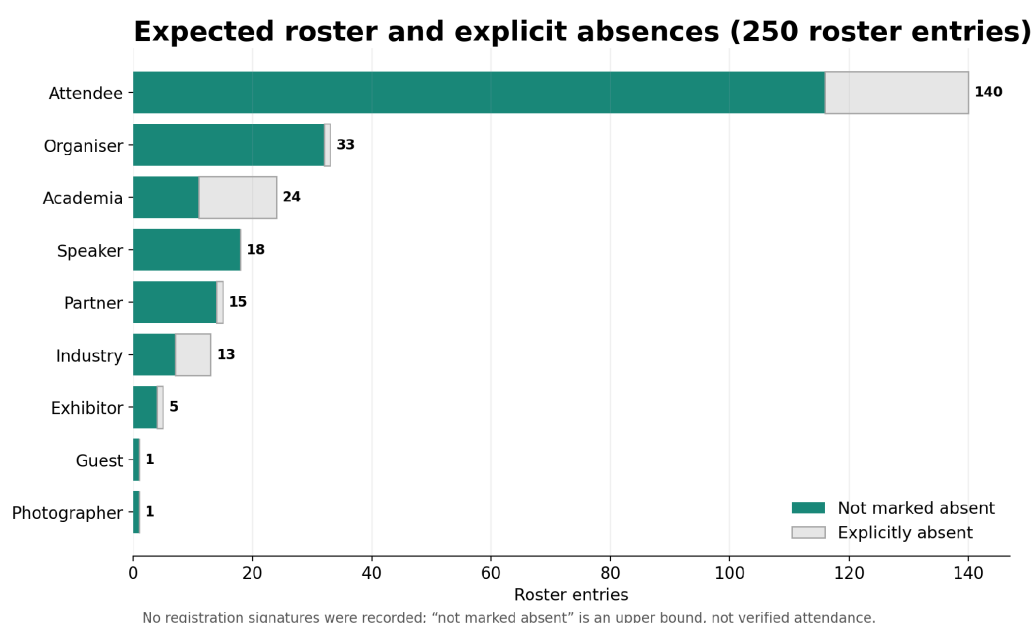


Figure 7: Expected roster by category, split between explicit absences and entries not marked absent.

7.1 Attendance interpretation

- The 250 roster entries equal 62.5% of the prospectus target of 400+ delegates.
- The 204 entries not marked absent equal 51.0% of the 400-delegate threshold, but this is only an upper bound based on incomplete check-in data.
- The roster contains 239 unique email addresses, so role duplication and duplicate registrations must be resolved before unique-person reporting.
- The records may omit walk-ins, day visitors or late additions; therefore they cannot prove either a target shortfall or final attendance.

8 PARTNERSHIPS AND STAKEHOLDER ENGAGEMENT

Partnerships are central to both programme delivery and financial sustainability. There were 13 sponsors and partners, along with 7 exhibitors.

9 FINANCIAL PERFORMANCE

Recorded expenditure totals R788,724.36, of which R769,737.76 is marked paid and R18,986.60 remains unpaid. Recorded income totals R772,496.43; R547,496.43 is marked received and R225,000.00 is pending. The resulting recorded balance is a deficit of R16,227.93.

9.1 Expenditure allocation

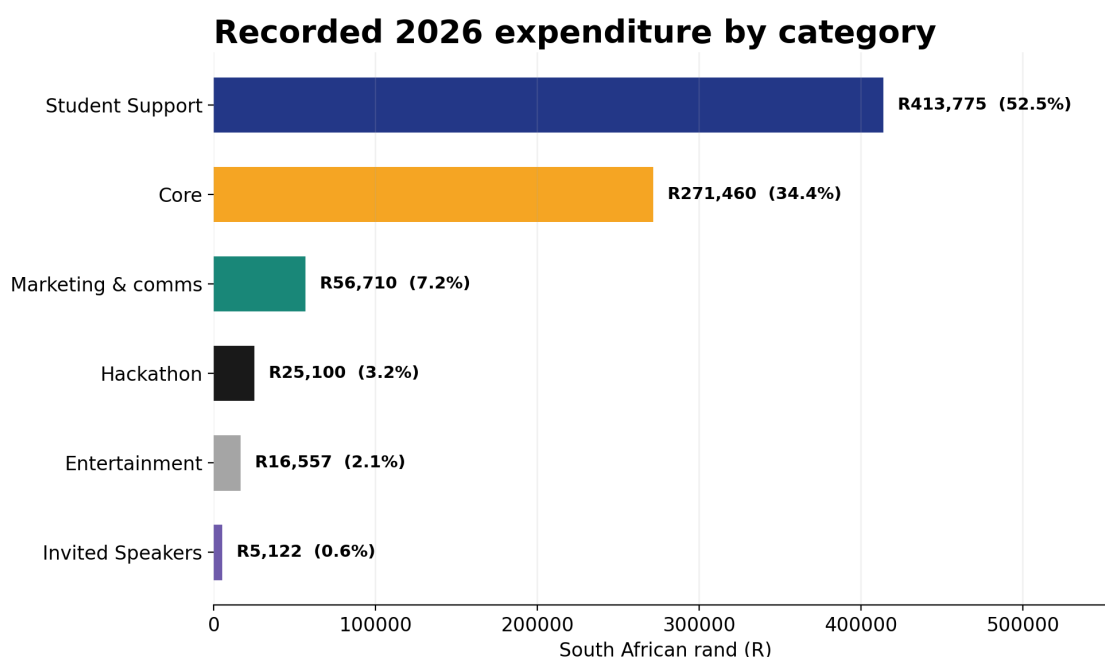


Figure 9: Recorded expense allocation by workbook category.

Student Support represents 52.5% of recorded expenditure, substantially above the prospectus strategic allocation of 32% for student support and travel awards. The comparison is directional because the workbook category also includes organiser travel, bus snacks and awards. Core expenditure, dominated by catering, accounts for 34.4% and is broadly consistent with the prospectus emphasis on events and catering.

10 CONCLUSION

IndabaX South Africa 2026 demonstrated substantial community demand, strong inclusion and an ambitious access-support and research programme. The accepted cohort achieved gender parity, the event invested more than half of recorded expenditure in student support, and the poster pipeline expanded significantly relative to the 2025 benchmark.

The primary improvement opportunity is not demand generation; it is operational evidence and reconciliation. A unified data model, digital attendance, closed grant statuses, aligned poster access and disciplined cash-flow reporting would convert the event from a strong community initiative with fragmented records into a fully measurable national platform.

With these controls in place, IndabaX South Africa will be better positioned to demonstrate impact to participants, universities, industry partners, funders and the wider Deep Learning Indaba community, while scaling access responsibly.

11 APPENDIX A: KPI DEFINITIONS AND CALCULATIONS

KPI	Calculation	Result
Application acceptance rate	189 / 389 final selection records	48.6%
Waitlist rate	191 / 389 final selection records	49.1%
Funded share of accepted cohort	130 / 189	68.8%
Operationalised grant share	98 / 130 awards	75.4%
Accepted women	94 / 189	49.7%
Funded women	68 / 130	52.3%
Accepted Black participants	160 / 189	84.7%
Student/postdoctoral accepted cohort	177 / 189	93.7%
Hackathon interest	338 / 391	86.4%
Device need among hackathon-interested	216 / 338	63.9%
Full five-day intent	323 / 391	82.6%
Support requested	330 / 391	84.4%
Poster women	41 / 103	39.8%
Poster pipeline growth vs 2025	$(103 - 60) / 60$	71.7%
Roster entries vs 400 target	250 / 400	62.5%
Not-marked-absent upper bound vs target	204 / 400	51.0%
Student Support expense share	R413,775 / R788,724.36	52.5%
Registration income share	R31,600 / R772,496.43	4.1%
Recorded deficit share	R16,227.93 / R788,724.36	2.1%

Percentages may differ by 0.1 percentage points because of rounding. Counts use the source hierarchy described in Section 3.

11.1 Privacy and retention note

Several source files contain special personal information, identity documents, bank account details, contact details, and free-text motivations. The aggregated report should be stored separately from these records. Access to the original files should be restricted, logged, and retained only for the period required by legal, grant, financial, and event-administration obligations.